

(c) Developmental Research

Developmental research is conducted for the purpose of predicting future trends. It concentrates on the study of variables, their rates of change, directions, sequences and other inter-related factors over a period of time. There are several methods of developmental research.

(1) Longitudinal Study

It is a research where phenomena are studied over time either continuously or repeatedly. This type of study measures the nature and rate of change in a sample at different stages of development. This occurs when the data are collected at two or more points in time from the same group of individuals. Because data are gathered at two different points in time, it is not a cross-sectional or a one-shot study, but it is a study carried longitudinally across a period of time. Longitudinal studies are mostly quantitative.

(1.a) Trend Study

The trend study is probably the most common longitudinal study among others. When the data are collected at intervals spread over a period of time, it is called a trend study. It is designed to establish patterns of change in the past in order to predict future patterns or conditions. A trend study thus provides information about net changes at an aggregate level. Marketing firms, for example, compile trend studies that chart fluctuations in consumption level for a certain product.

This type of study is particularly used to obtain and analyze social, economic, and political data to identify trends and to predict what is likely to take place in the future. Frequently regression analysis is used for trend studies.

(1.b) Cohort Study

A cohort is a group of people who share a common characteristic or experience within a defined period. Thus, cohort study is a study of a specific group, such as those born on a day or in the particular period, say in the year 2003. This group then forms a birth cohort or a kindergarten cohort. Similarly, a group of students graduating from college in a year form a student cohort. There are many other kinds of cohorts, including disease, education, employment, housing, family formation, and the like.

A sample of the selected cohort group is then studied at different points of time. A cohort study is thus a systematic follow-up of a group of people for a defined period of time or until a specified event. To form cohort studies, data are compiled for the same population over time. Such studies are therefore rare because of the difficulty of maintaining contact with members of the cohort from year to year.

(1.c) Panel Study

A panel is a group of individuals that have agreed to provide information to a researcher over period of time. In panel study we take the same people and study their attitudes towards particular phenomenon over time. Panel studies are most useful when studying change. These studies allow the researcher to find out why changes in the population are occurring. They measure the same sample of respondents at different points in time. For example, if we were interested in finding out the general attitude towards single parenthood, we would take a group of people and interview them at periodic intervals on the same subject and over a number of years.

(2.0) Cross-sectional Study

This type of study is also known as cross-sectional analysis. It involves observation of some items of the population all at the same time. This study basically measures the rates of changes by drawing samples from a cross-section of society. It focuses on comparing and describing groups. In this study, data are gathered just once, perhaps over a period of time, in order to answer a research question. Such studies are also known as one-shot studies. Cross-sectional studies often employ the survey strategy. The fundamental difference between a cross-sectional study and longitudinal study is that a cross-sectional study takes place at a single point of time and that a longitudinal study involves a series of measurements taken over a period of time.

Characteristics of developmental Research

- Developmental research focuses on the study of variables and their development over a period of months or years. It asks, "What are the patterns of growth, their rates, their directions, their sequences, and the interrelated factors affecting these characteristics?"
- The sampling problem in the longitudinal method is complicated by the limited number of subjects it can follow over the years; any selected factor affecting attrition biases the longitudinal study.
- Once underway, the longitudinal method does not lend itself to improvements in techniques without losing the continuity of staff and financial support over an extended period of time and typically is confined to university or foundation centers that can maintain such an effort.
- Cross-sectional studies usually include more subjects, but describe fewer growth factors than longitudinal studies. While the latter is the only direct method of studying human development, the cross-sectional approach is less expensive and faster since the actual passage of time is eliminated by sampling different subjects across age ranges.
- Sampling in the cross-sectional method is complicated because the same children are not involved at each age level and may not be comparable.

(d) Survey Research

A survey is a means of gathering information about the characteristics, actions, or opinions of a large group of people, referred to as a population. A survey research is thus defined as "the Systematic gathering of information from respondents for the purpose of understanding and/or predicting some aspect of the behavior of the population of interest". If conducted scientifically this type of research can contribute to the advance of knowledge.

A Survey study may be done in the field - an example would be a survey of employee attitudes toward a new compensation policy- or it may take in a library, where a survey of secondary literature is conducted. In survey research, the researcher selects a sample of respondents from a population and administers a standardized questionnaire to them. Hence, using surveys it is possible to collect data from large or small populations.

Types of Survey Research

- Exploratory survey research. This type of survey research takes place during the early stages of research. It provides the basis for more in-depth surveys. Sometimes, this kind of survey is carried out using data collected in previous studies.
- Confirmatory (theory-testing or explanatory) survey research. In this type of survey, data collection is done with specific aim of testing the theory or hypothesis.
- Descriptive survey research. This type of survey research describes the distribution of the phenomenon in a population.

The aim of survey research is to measure certain attitudes or behavior of a population or a sample. The attitudes might be opinions about the services provided by a business firm or feelings about certain issues or practices. Most often respondents are asked for information. Surveys come in a wide range of forms and can be distributed using a variety of media: written surveys, oral surveys, or electronic surveys. The questionnaire, or survey, can be a written document that is completed by the person being surveyed, on online questionnaire, a face-to-face interview, a mail survey, or a telephone interview. Some forms of survey research by telephone or Internet may be completely automated. Using surveys, it is possible to collect data from large or small population.